extend his best wishes. He would also call up on other occasions too, to extend his condolences. I assured the Commander-in-Chief that the Army was in fine fettle and ready to take on any challenges that may arise in the future. The President expressed his regrets that it was unfortunate that we had not been able to meet more often in person due to the Covid pandemic but that was unavoidable. Veena apprised Smt. Savita Kovind about all the work done by the AWWA, for the welfare of our families and next-of-kin of our fallen soldiers. With that, we took our leave.

On 30 April 2022, I got up as usual and changed into my uniform. In my engagements of the day, Nb Sub SK Tiwari, my PA, who had been with me for some time, efficient as always, had very helpfully entered 'Retirement Day'. I went out and inspected the Residential Guard and gave them my 'Shabash' for their hard work. We had already had a high-tea the previous evening to bid farewell to all the staff. Our personal effects had all been packed and moved to 20 Mandir Marg in Delhi Cantt, since as per tradition, once the outgoing Chief completes the handing-over formalities, he does not return to the Army House. Once you leave, you leave. Veena, Isha and Simon and Arvin (my grandson), Amala and her fiancé Rahul, my mother-in-law, were all present. From the Army House, we went to the National War Memorial where I laid a wreath for the last time. During the two-minute silence, I made a silent prayer for all those brave souls who had died on my watch, whether due to enemy action or natural calamities. Seeing the National Flag flutter in the early morning breeze to the strains of the 'Last Post' brought a lump to my throat.

From there to the lawns of the South Block for the Ceremonial Guard of Honour. Before entering the South Block, I had a quick word and handshakes with my journalist

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